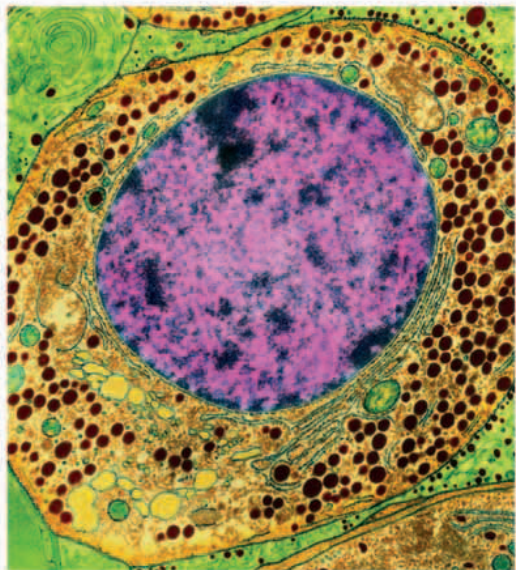


Growth hormone

The speed at which your body grows during childhood and the teenage years is controlled by a chemical called growth hormone. Released into the blood by the pituitary gland in the brain, growth hormone affects every part of the body. It makes organs larger, muscles stronger, and bones longer, slowly transforming your body.

HOW GROWTH HORMONE WORKS

Growth hormone makes body cells divide, causing organs to grow larger and muscles to become bulkier. In the liver, it triggers the release of another hormone, IGF-1, which makes bones extend. During the early teenage years, sex hormones cause the pituitary gland to release extra growth hormone, leading to a spurt in growth. Afterward, growth hormone levels fall steeply as you reach adulthood and stop growing.



HORMONE CELL

Growth hormone is made by specialized cells in the pituitary gland. The image above, taken by an electron microscope, shows one such cell. In the middle of the cell is its control center, the nucleus (purple). Outside this are numerous granules (brown) that store newly made growth hormone, ready to be released.

Growth hormone also boosts your body's immune system.

